Task, Decision, Trigger, Review Date

A one-page sheet of planning words and what to write down for each.

Planning ahead comes with its own small vocabulary: trigger, owner, backup, review date. People use the words as if everyone had agreed what they mean. Here are sixteen of them in one plain line each, with what to jot down when one comes up.

Most are planning words, given the way the Family Care Roadmap uses them. Where a word has a public definition, its source is numbered. The definitions are for keeping a family conversation straight. They don't measure anything about Mom.

Sorting what's on the list

Preparation

Anything that helps whatever happens and commits Mom to nothing.

WRITE DOWN The things the family could usefully get ready this season.

Decision

A choice that would commit Mom to something. Planning ahead leaves the ones that aren't due.

WRITE DOWN Each one the family has chosen to wait on, worded that way.

Task

A small, specific job one person can do: a phone call, a conversation, an afternoon with the papers.

WRITE DOWN The job in one line, starting with a verb.

Prerequisite

Something that has to be known or done before another item can start. An unanswered question is one kind.

WRITE DOWN What the item is waiting on, and who could find out.

Monitoring

Keeping an eye on something without acting on it.

WRITE DOWN What you're keeping an eye on, and where you'll note what you see.

Sharing it around

Owner

The person who has agreed to see a task through. Agreed, not been given.

WRITE DOWN A name, once that person has said yes.

Backup

Someone who would step in on an important task if the owner couldn't.

WRITE DOWN Who has offered, for the tasks that matter most.

Point person

AARP's word for the person who keeps the process moving and makes sure people understand what's been decided. [1]

WRITE DOWN Who has agreed to be it.

Planning file

The one place the family's lists, notes and contacts are kept: a folder, a notebook or a shared document.

WRITE DOWN Where it is, and who keeps it up to date.

Family meeting

A meeting of everyone who is or will be part of the caregiving team, which may include a family friend or a neighbor. The Family Caregiver Alliance suggests preparing an agenda first. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who should be there, and what's on the agenda.

Coming back to it

Review date

The day the family has picked to look at the plan again. The CDC's advice for a care plan is every year, or more often if the person's health or medicines change. [3]

WRITE DOWN The date, on the page itself.

Trigger

An everyday change the family has agreed would bring it back to the plan before the review date.

WRITE DOWN The change, in plain words. Which changes should count for Mom is a question for your care consultant.

Care plan

A form that summarizes a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments. [3]

WRITE DOWN Whether Mom has one, and who keeps it.

People to ask

Professional review

An item on the list that belongs to a professional, not to the family. Anything about Mom's health is one.

WRITE DOWN The question, who it's for, and who in the family will ask.

Eldercare Locator

A public service of the federal Administration for Community Living that connects older adults and their families to services. The number is 1-800-677-1116. [5]

WRITE DOWN The number, and what you'd ask about.

Care manager

A professional, also called a case manager, who usually has a background in counseling, social work or a related healthcare field and is trained to assess an individual situation and to implement and monitor a care plan. [4]

WRITE DOWN Whether the family has spoken with one, and what you'd ask.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't fill in your family's roadmap, put names beside tasks, or say which changes should count for Mom.

Ready for the next step?

You know what the planning words mean and what to jot down under each. The care interview supplies what the words are about: it walks you through Mom's situation today, area by area, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

Point person, family meeting, care plan, care manager and the Eldercare Locator are described as the numbered sources describe them, and the advice on how often to update a care plan is the CDC's. The other planning words are given the way the Family Care Roadmap uses them.

1. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
4. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving at Home: A Guide to Community Resources
5. Administration for Community Living, Eldercare Locator